of her, looking directly at her. The rest of the crew, too, had encircled the couple, leaving them baffled. A disappointed Ragothaman let them go and waved at his people to move away.

Kaarthikeyan and Raju monitored the operation from in front of a wireless station in Malligai. While Kaarthikeyan looked tense and stiff after learning about the ‘false lead’ at Chromepet and a similar dead end at the Alandur bus halt, Raju got Kanth on the line from the Tambaram check post.

Kanth and his team were painstakingly checking every vehicle that passed by. Their flashlights on the drivers and occupants of the vehicles, however, showed no sign of either Nalini or Murugan. The darkness, the indistinct chatter over the wireless sets, the flashlights searching the vehicles and passengers, the presence of plainclothes policemen and vehicles queued up for clearance had turned the atmosphere eerie. Kanth had nothing encouraging to offer Raju when he called. ‘So far, two leads only,’ he said. ‘Both turned out to be false. We will continue looking, though.’

The place with maximum activity was the bus terminus at Saidapet. Black Cat commandos kept watch through binoculars from building rooftops surrounding the terminus. They literally checked from person to person, passenger to passenger. On the ground, Kanth sat in disguise as a bus driver parked alongside rows of other buses. Not very far was Ravindran, who was waiting inside the office of the terminus along with six Black Cat commandos strategically posted inside the depot. There was no sign of the wanted couple. Unable to deal with the mosquitos, Kanth once asked over the wireless set if anyone could arrange for a mosquito repellant. The last thing he wanted was to fall sick with malaria or dengue.

It was over three hours now. A dull hopelessness had seeped into the tracking team. Ragothaman was back in Malligai. Kaarthikeyan asked him and Raju if the duo might have got off somewhere before the terminus at Saidapet. What if they had cancelled their trip back to Madras? What if they had got off the bus before it entered the city? Questions were many but answers hardly in sight.